because of his predilection, according to Fayz Mohammad, ‘for inciting peaceful people to engage in mischief’.[141] Mackenzie was later told by Aminullah’s brother, who ended up a refugee in Ludhiana, that Dost Mohammad, ‘having married a daughter of Aminullah, had then murdered him with his own hands, smothering him with a pillow’.[142]

Wazir Akbar Khan enjoyed a year of power after the British left, but on the return of his father in 1843 was sent off to be governor of Jalalabad and Laghman. His durbar soon came to be seen as a centre of opposition to Dost Mohammad. When Akbar Khan was poisoned in 1847 it was widely rumoured that it was on his father’s orders.[143] Just before he died, Akbar wrote a last letter to Mackenzie, ‘affectionately reproaching him for his neglect of the duties of friendship in not giving him news of his welfare’. Mackenzie was forbidden by the government from answering the letter ‘as it was from an enemy’.[144] Mackenzie did however answer a letter from Mohammad Shah Khan Ghilzai, who, having become too powerful for the liking of Dost Mohammad, had fallen from favour and been ruined soon after the death of his son-in-law. Forced to flee into exile among the Kafirstanis of Nuristan, he wrote to Mackenzie in Ludhiana to remind him ‘of their former friendship and to ask if it continued’.

> The letter was brought by a Sayad, to whom he had given a token whereby he might judge of Mackenzie’s disposition towards him. The Sayad began: ‘Mohammad Shah Khan says to you, “when you were in peril of life by the fort of Mahmud Khan [after the murder of Macnaghten] how did I act?”’ Mackenzie answered: ‘When the sword was raised to strike me, he put his arm round my neck and took the cut on his own shoulder.’ Then the Sayad knew he might deliver the letter. Mackenzie replied that he ‘would always acknowledge him as a friend’.[145]

The only man who clearly gained from the First Anglo-Afghan War was the very man whom the war was designed to depose. In April 1843, after staying as the guest of the Sikh Khalsa in Lahore, Dost Mohammad rode to Peshawar and mounted the switchbacks of the Khyber. At Ali Masjid he was greeted by Akbar Khan and escorted by him back to Kabul. ‘The residents of that city lined the route,’ wrote Fayz Mohammad. ‘Old and young alike cheered his arrival and the eyes of his supporters were dazzled and their breasts swelled with pride at the sight of him. With joy increasing, they sang his praises, and together they entered Kabul in a state of complete euphoria. For seven days and nights there were joyous celebrations. The nights were brightened with lights and the days with the sounds of people